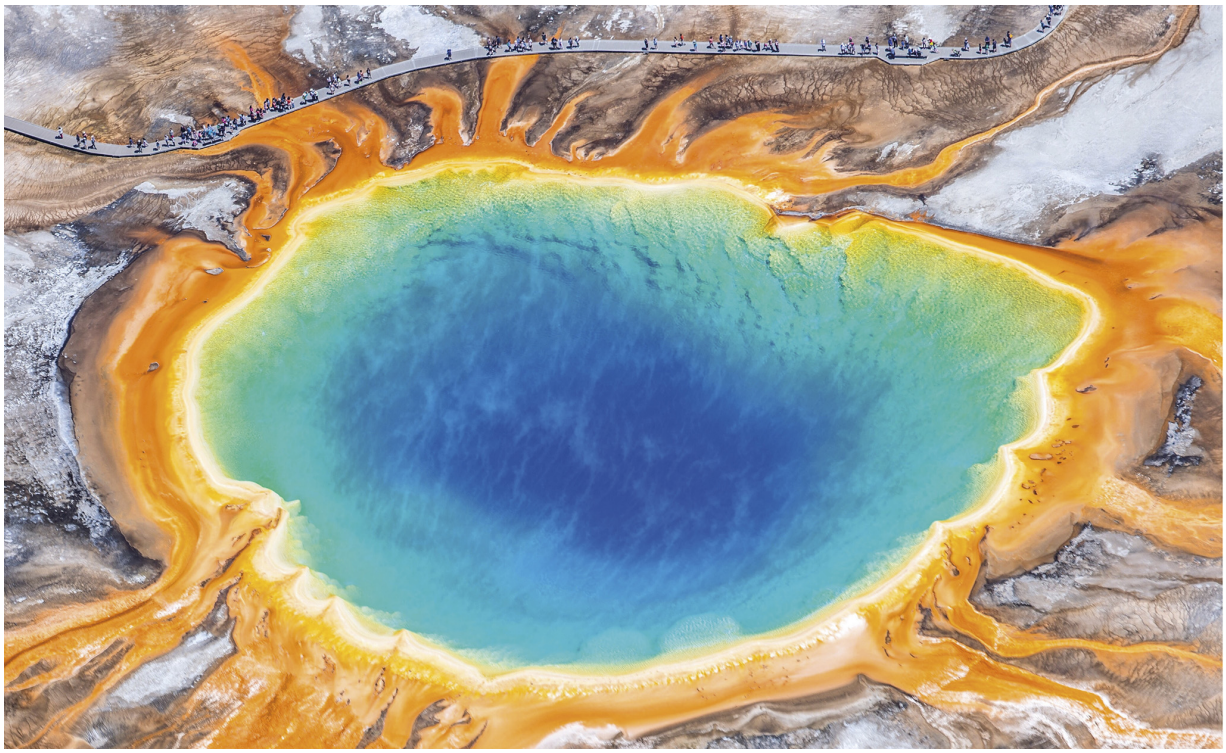
did not match the tree of life model, in which clades—groups of organisms with a common ancestry—spring as branches from the previous fork.

Woese sought a classification system that reflected the intricacies of evolution—with main branches on the tree of life splitting into smaller ones, and even tinier twigs that end in the leaves of individual species. In the future, the complex tree of life may reveal even more evolutionary categories.



Sulfur-dependent archaea organisms thrive in the hot geothermal pools of Yellowstone National Park, Wyoming, in conditions that would kill most other organisms.